

Indian Army artillerymen fire on Pakistani positions, 15 December 1971. (AFP via Getty Images)

Operations on the eastern front

In the south-western sector bounded by the Padma in the north, the Jamuna in the east and the Bay of Bengal in the south, II Corps had 4 Mountain Division and 9 Infantry Division supported by one regiment and one squadron of armour. During the battle of Boyra in November, II Corps had gained a foothold in Pakistan and destroyed the only Pakistani armoured squadron in the sector, giving the Indians an advantage subsequently. The action at Garibpur had alerted the Pakistanis to the Indian Army's likely line of advance, however, and 9 Infantry Division thus faced tough opposition at Jessore. The Pakistani forces withdrew to Daulatpur, Khulna and east of the Madhumati River on the night of 6/7 December, with Indian troops occupying Jessore later that day. Major General Dalbir Singh, GOC 9 Infantry Division, got distracted at this stage and turned his entire division towards Khulna, a brigade-level objective; his division failed to capture Khulna despite repeated attacks.

By 5 December, 4 Mountain Division captured Darsana and Kotchandpur. On 8 December, it captured Magura and reached the